



TAMPA BAY WATERFRONT · 2026 EDITION

Tampa Dock *Planning Kit*

The waterfront owner's field guide to permits, costs, and hiring the right builder.

PERMITS

Every agency, every project type

COSTS

Real Tampa numbers + a worksheet

BUILDERS

12 questions before you sign



START HERE

Welcome — you're in the right place.

Building or repairing something on Tampa Bay water is easy to mess up. This kit is the shortcut: a checklist of every permit you'll need, real cost numbers you can plug into a worksheet, and the exact questions to ask any builder before you hand over a deposit.

INSIDE

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HOW TO USE THIS KIT

Print the checklist. Fill in the worksheet with quotes as they come in. Read the 12 questions before your first builder call.



SECTION 01

Permit Checklist by Project

Six common Tampa Bay projects and the agencies that touch each one. Print this and check off each approval as it lands.

New dock construction

10–20 weeks total

AGENCIES REQUIRED

- ☒ County building dept
- ☒ County environmental / EPC
- ☒ Florida DEP (submerged lands)
- ☒ US Army Corps of Engineers

NOTES

- Small single-family docks often qualify for an FDEP exemption but still need county sign-off.
- Docks over 500 sq ft or in seagrass beds trigger longer FDEP + ACOE review.

Dock repair / rebuild in-kind

3–6 weeks

AGENCIES REQUIRED

- ☒ County building dept
- ☐ County environmental / EPC (typically not required)
- ☐ Florida DEP (typically not required)
- ☐ US Army Corps of Engineers (typically not required)

NOTES

- 'In-kind' means same footprint, same materials. Any expansion bumps you to full new-dock permitting.

SECTION 01 · CONTINUED

Permit Checklist by Project

Boat lift installation

6–14 weeks

AGENCIES REQUIRED

- ☒ County building dept
- ☐ County environmental / EPC (typically not required)
- ☒ Florida DEP
- ☒ US Army Corps of Engineers

NOTES

- Lifts occupy submerged land, so ACOE + FDEP always review.
- Bundle with a dock permit if you're building both — most builders will.

New seawall / full replacement

12–24 weeks

AGENCIES REQUIRED

- ☒ County building dept
- ☒ County environmental / EPC
- ☒ Florida DEP
- ☒ US Army Corps of Engineers

NOTES

- Replacement in the same footprint is faster than a brand-new install.
- Seagrass mitigation and endangered species review can add 8–16 weeks.

SECTION 01 · CONTINUED

Permit Checklist by Project

Seawall cap-only refresh

2–5 weeks

AGENCIES REQUIRED

- ☒ County building dept
- ☐ County environmental / EPC (typically not required)
- ☐ Florida DEP (typically not required)
- ☐ US Army Corps of Engineers (typically not required)

NOTES

- Cap-only usually needs only a county building permit.
- If panels are compromised, expect to be pushed to full replacement.

Post-storm rebuild (declared disaster)

6–18 weeks (expedited path exists)

AGENCIES REQUIRED

- ☒ County building dept
- ☒ County environmental / EPC
- ☒ Florida DEP
- ☒ US Army Corps of Engineers

NOTES

- Post-disaster expedited review is available — declare intent to rebuild within 90 days for the fastest track.
- FEMA 50% rule: if repair cost exceeds 50% of the structure's pre-storm value, current code applies (BFE, wind, elevation).

SECTION 02

Dock Cost Worksheet

Reference numbers from real Tampa Bay quotes (2026). Use the worksheet below to plug in what each builder tells you and compare side-by-side.

COMPONENT	LOW	HIGH
Permit fees (all agencies)	\$800	\$3,500
Site survey & design drawings	\$1,200	\$4,000
Pilings (per piling, installed)	\$450	\$900
Decking — pressure-treated pine	\$28/sqft	\$42/sqft
Decking — composite (Trex / TimberTech)	\$45/sqft	\$70/sqft
Decking — ipe or cumaru hardwood	\$60/sqft	\$95/sqft
Boat lift (4,500–10,000 lb capacity)	\$5,500	\$14,000
Electrical / dock lighting package	\$1,800	\$6,000
Water line + shore power pedestal	\$1,200	\$3,500
Seawall cap refresh (per linear ft)	\$120/ft	\$220/ft
New seawall (per linear ft)	\$550/ft	\$1,100/ft

Your quote worksheet

LINE ITEM	BUILDER A	BUILDER B	BUILDER C
Permits & design			
Pilings			
Decking			
Boat lift			
Electrical			
Water / power			
Extras			
TOTAL			



SECTION 03

12 Questions to Ask Any Builder

The single best filter you have is a written Q&A. Ask every builder these before signing. The ones who give straight answers usually build straight docks.

01

Are you licensed in Florida and insured for marine construction?

Ask for the CBC/CGC number + a certificate of insurance naming you as certificate holder.

02

How many Tampa Bay dock permits have you pulled in the last 12 months?

You want a real number, not 'lots'. 20+ is healthy for a busy builder.

03

Which agencies will YOU handle vs. which do I handle?

The right answer is 'all of them'. If they punt FDEP or ACOE to you, that's a red flag.

04

Can I see three finished projects nearby I can visit?

Drive-by evidence beats Instagram. Ask for addresses, not just photos.

05

What's the payment schedule and what triggers each draw?

You should never pay more than 30% up front. Draws should tie to milestones, not calendar dates.

06

What are you not including in this price?

Get the exclusions in writing: permits, mobilization, tie-off pilings, electric, water, lift, cleanup.



SECTION 03 (CONT.)

12 Questions (continued)

07

What's the warranty on labor vs. materials, in writing?

1 year labor is standard. Material warranties vary — composite decking often has 25 years.

08

How do you handle change orders?

Written change orders, priced in advance, signed before work starts. Verbal changes will burn you.

09

What's your worst-case delay if permits slip?

A good builder has real numbers. 'It'll be fine' is not a real answer.

10

Who is my day-to-day point of contact?

Not the sales person. A project manager or foreman who returns texts within a business day.

11

What's your protocol if a hurricane hits mid-build?

Materials tied down, site secured, timeline reset in writing. Ask what happened during Ian/Idalia.

12

Can I see a sample contract before I sign?

Yes is the only right answer. Read it. Look for auto-renewal, liquidated damages, and arbitration clauses.



SECTION 04

Red Flags to Watch For

If a builder does any of these, keep shopping. Docks are a 20-year investment; take the extra week.

- ✗ Asks for more than 30% up front, or wants full payment before permits are pulled.
- ✗ Won't share a certificate of insurance or license number.
- ✗ Only shows photos — refuses to give addresses of finished nearby projects.
- ✗ Verbal quote only, refuses to put exclusions in writing.
- ✗ Vague warranty ('we stand behind our work') without a written term.
- ✗ Pressures you to sign 'today' for a special price.
- ✗ No project manager or single point of contact after the sale.
- ✗ Won't handle FDEP or ACOE permits ('you do that part').

SECTION 05 · NEXT STEPS

Ready to get real quotes?

Fill out one form. We match you with two or three licensed Tampa Bay builders. No spam, no auto-dialers, no fees to you — ever.

Get matched →

mydockguide.com/quote